



What makes merchants pay and consumers play?

A deep dive into validating a B2C rewards platform for a B2B fintech

DURATION

ROLE

COLLABORATORS

STAKEHOLDERS



1.
Merchant
- 2.1.
Consumer
- FGD
- 2.2
Consumer
- Survey

10 weeks,
May 2024

Lead
UX Researcher

D2C

- Product strategist
- Product Designer
- Market researcher
(for consumer survey)

Director of Product
strategy, Head of
strategy & corp
dev, CEO &
MD, Product
strategy
Consultants

De-risking a strategic proposal for a two-sided marketplace and unlocking multi-million dollar investment

Razorpay is a 7.5 Billion dollars B2B Indian start up solving for 8M+ businesses' end to end money movements

Project Background

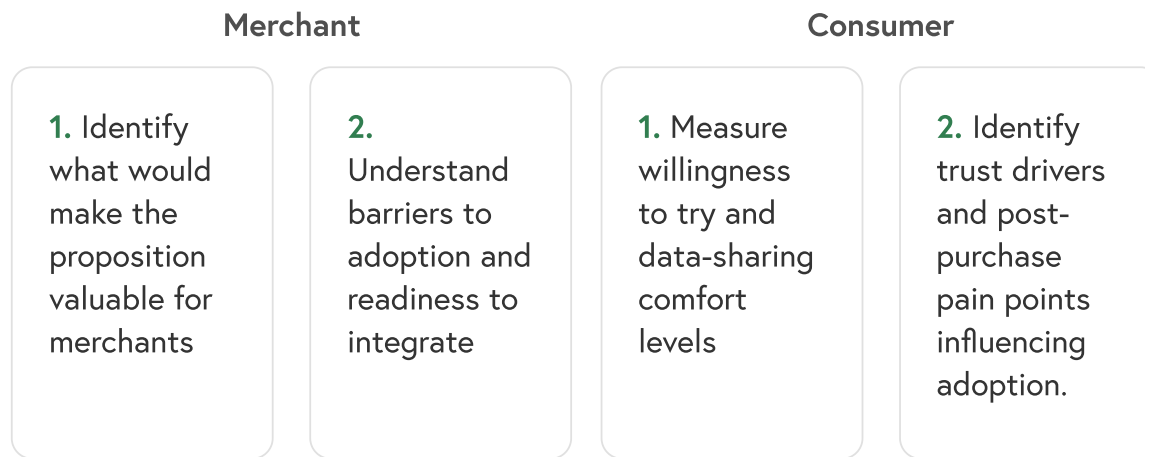
Business Context

Razorpay, a leading fintech company processing payments for 50,000+ merchants identified a strategic threat: competitors with B2C consumer networks were beginning to win B2B market due to brand recognition. The company needed to evaluate whether expanding into B2C through a rewards platform could defend against this disruption.

Research Challenge

The strategy team proposed a two-sided marketplace concept. Merchants would fund rewards that consumers could earn across brands. Before committing, leadership required validation. I partnered with the a Product Strategist to design and execute a comprehensive validation study addressing whether

Objectives

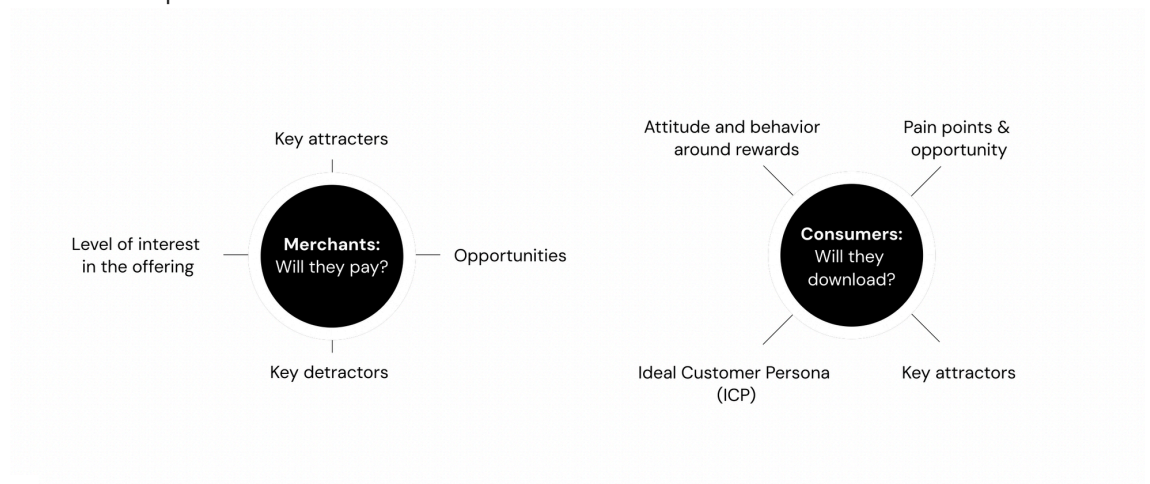


Methodology

I developed a mixed-methods approach with parallel research streams to validate both sides of the marketplace simultaneously.

Marketplace: In depth participatory interviews

Consumers: FGD for exploration and hypothesis, large survey for quantitative validation



1. Merchant

Study Design:

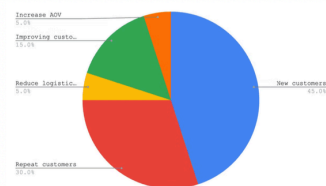
Conducted 40+ in-depth interviews with merchant decision-makers ac



- 50-minute semi-structured interview

1. Pain points
2. Piggy bank exercise to break down problem priority based on money allocated
2. Participatory design activity for ideal solution
3. Introduced our proposal
4. Willingness to pay

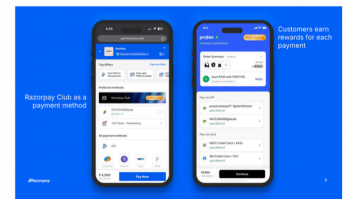
Through the interviews we found that our proposed value proposition had very little interest. However, the participatory design activity helped us pivot and find a new model that worked for both merchants, and our company.



"If you had Rs.100, how would you spend it on the following goals?"



"What are the key things that an ideal platform should offer?"



Appeal & Comprehension
Relevance
Uniqueness + Credibility
Willingness to Trial

2. Consumer - Focus Group Discussions

FGDs were conducted to get a general user understanding and broad archetypes to create a more efficient survey. Sessions employed journey mapping exercises, pain point exploration through storytelling, and progressive concept testing. The group dynamic enabled participants to build on and challenge each other's perspectives, revealing more nuanced opinions about the D2C shopping experience.

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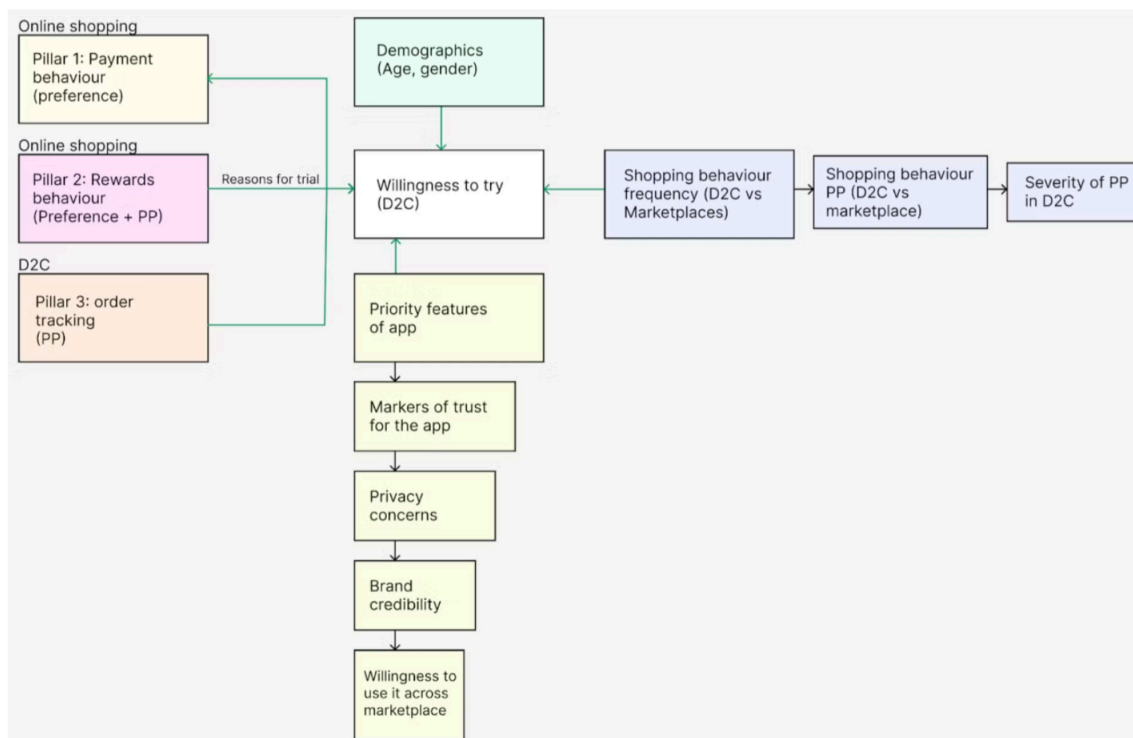


Section	Objective
Warmup and intro (10)	At the end of this section, we will need to have gotten the group acquainted with each other, and open them up for a collaborative group experience
D2C vs Marketplace (30)	At the end of this section, we should have all the disadvantages of shopping from a D2C website...
Rewards Deep Dive (25)	At the end of this section, we should have an understanding of consumers' spontaneous reactions to rewards, how much they actually value or think about these rewards... (we have to gauge the extent of pain and therefore opportunity for our rewards app)
Idealization Exercise (20)	Features that are paramount to the success of the rewards app
Prioritisation(5)	Wrap up group with key benefits

2. Consumer Survey

Partnered with a market researcher to field a survey to 1,000+ respondents. The survey resulted in:

- Feature prioritisation
- Willingness to try scores
- Behavioral assessment for archetype creation
- Potential Unique Value



Outcome

- Defined key consumer personas to clarify who the proposition serves best and where adoption is most likely.
- Identified customer hooks that drive adoption, clarifying which trust and post-purchase pain points

addressed first.

- **Prioritized features into must-haves and good-to-haves**, providing clear guidance for MVP scope and sequencing.
- **Reframed the merchant value proposition** by identifying what makes participation worthwhile and where the original assumptions did not hold.
- **Narrowed the merchant segments** for which the proposition is most viable, enabling a more focused go-to-market strategy.



Impact

The research directly informed the executive decision to proceed with investment

- Rather than a binary go/no-go outcome, the findings enabled leadership to make nuanced decisions about investment structure, phasing, and success metrics.
- The research reframed the product strategy. Instead of a simple rewards platform, the concept evolved into a trust and reliability solution for end consumers to build trust in D2C market.
- The merchant segmentation and consumer adoption patterns identified through research directly influenced go-to-market strategy. Instead of a broad market launch, the findings supported a targeted approach focusing on specific merchant segments with highest likelihood of success.
- The collaborative research process created shared understanding across product, strategy, and executive teams. By involving stakeholders throughout data collection and synthesis, the research built consensus around market realities that lasted beyond the project itself. This alignment accelerated decision-making and reduced the typical friction between strategic vision and market reality.

Since this project is under NDA, to know more [reach out to me!](#)



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Conclusion & learnings

This project reinforced that the core value of user research lies in framing the right questions and defining what evidence is sufficient to make decisions. Rather than optimizing for exhaustive coverage, I learned the importance of designing research that is proportional to the risk being tested and deliberately avoids premature validation. Working across consumers and merchants highlighted how easily research can skew toward one-sided desirability if incentives are not explicitly examined.

Found anything interesting?
Hit me up to discuss about how
fascinating our species is or to
go gaga over underground indie
and old hindi music! :')

PS: best viewed on laptop



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